

To do and for doing

Teaching guide

Explain a purpose or the function of an object.

Understand the distinction

Use to + base verb to explain an action's purpose: I went out to buy bread. Use for + noun for a purpose or recipient: a bag for groceries; a gift for Lee.

For + -ing often describes a function: a tool for opening bottles. A to-infinitive can also describe a use: something to open bottles with. Do not use for buying to explain why you went out in the basic I went out to buy pattern.

Compare the patterns

PURPOSE OF ACTION

I called to ask a question.

To ask gives the reason for calling.

FUNCTION

This brush is for cleaning shoes.

For cleaning describes the use.

RECIPIENT

This message is for Ana.

Ana is the intended recipient.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: I am saving money ___ buy a bike.

A. for

B. to

C. for to

2. Complete: This tool is for ___ cans. (open)

A. opened

B. open

C. opening

3. Choose the correction: I went to the shop for buy milk.

A. I went to the shop to buy milk.

B. I went to the shop to buying milk.

C. I went to the shop for to buy milk.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly gives a purpose for a bottle and the function of a brush?

- A. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.
- B. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for to cleaning it.
- C. I bought a bottle for carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. to

Use the infinitive to express the purpose of saving.

A: For buy is not the purpose pattern. Use to buy.

C: Use to buy without adding for in this standard pattern.

2. C. opening

A verb after for takes the -ing form.

A: The function is expressed with for opening, not the past form.

B: For takes the -ing form here: for opening.

3. A. I went to the shop to buy milk.

To buy explains the purpose of the trip.

B: After to in this infinitive, use the base verb buy.

C: Use to buy in this standard purpose sentence.

4. A. I bought a bottle to carry water. This small brush is for cleaning it.

To carry gives the purpose; for cleaning gives the brush's function.

B: Use for cleaning, without to.

C: Use to carry to express this purpose.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-29.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair correctly gives a purpose for a bottle and the function of a brush?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.